

Projector owners: a tiny habit that adds years

Dust is the projector's enemy. Epson's maintenance guide calls for filter checks/cleaning when vents are dusty or indicator lights flash – power down, open the filter door, and clean or replace as specified. Make that a first-of-the-month ritual during dusty seasons.

Also: Never yank power before the fan has finished its cool-down; lamp and optics last longer when you respect the thermal cycle.

Power: Surge vs UPS

Brownouts and mini-outages are common in Indian homes. A surge protector clamps voltage spikes; a UPS keeps gear alive through short outages and allows clean shutdowns. Guides comparing the two make the division simple: surge = protection, UPS = protection + temporary power. Put your router/ONT + main mesh node and (if you use one) HTPC/console on the UPS; big power-draw gear like amplifiers usually go surge-only unless your UPS is sized for it.

Note: APC states their Back-UPS/Smart-UPS lines already include proper surge suppression – don't daisy-chain surge strips into UPS battery outlets.

Accessibility that benefits all

Turn on the features that make life easier for all ages:

- **Apple TV:** VoiceOver and Zoom can make menus readable from farther away; triple-press shortcuts are quick to toggle.
- **Google TV / Android TV:** TalkBack, captions, high-contrast text, and switch access live under Settings ► Accessibility.

These help elders navigate modern UIs and make your system more inclusive by default.

Sensible upgrade roadmap

Months 0–3:

Stabilize the network (wired backhaul), calibrate HDR, update firmware, disable ACR, and add UPS to keep the network alive during short power cuts.

Months 4–9:

If dialogue intelligibility still nags you, consider a real center speaker (in AVR setups) or a soundbar with dedicated center channel. Re-map seating to match Dolby's angles first; it's cheaper and often enough.

For projector homes, evaluate an ALR screen if you fight daylight; keep up filter care.

Months 10–18:

Upgrade streaming device first if your TV's apps feel slow; newer dongles often bring better codecs, smoother UIs, and extended update life.

TROUBLESHOOTING: FASTEST FIXES

- **Lip-sync echo between rooms (TV audio grouped to other rooms):** Use your ecosystem's TV-audio grouping delay controls or simply keep the TV room on "TV," the others on "music." (HEOS, Sonos, etc., expose TV audio delay/sync options.)
- **Random stream dropouts:** Wire the nearest node to the TV stand, verify Ethernet backhaul, and keep the streamer on 5/6 GHz.
- **HDR looks dim/washed:** Re-run the console/Windows calibration in your current picture mode and lighting.
- **No Atmos to the bar/AVR:** Confirm eARC is enabled on both TV and audio device, and that your app is playing the Atmos track.
- **Hearing fatigue:** Drop the master volume 3–5 dB, raise the center channel a touch, or enable Night/Dynamic Range mode. (Remember WHO's exposure limits.)

Add rear surrounds or height channels (or up-firing modules) once bass and center clarity are solid; follow Dolby's placement matrices.

Months 18–24:

If you watch lots of ad-supported streaming and want privacy, consider moving heavy viewing to a non-smart display + external streamer where you can tightly control tracking – and keep ACR off on the smart TV. (Consumer Reports' instructions help you verify settings on major platforms.)

Planning a new TV? Check the BEE label and short-list models with eARC + full HDMI 2.1 feature support (VRR, QMS/QFT/ALLM), so your next upgrade is "plug and play" with existing consoles and AVRs.

Always remember

The most satisfying entertainment setups aren't the most expensive – they're the most coherent. They respect your room, your network, your hearing, and your time. Spend one evening on calibration, one weekend on wiring and privacy, and one hour every quarter on maintenance. The result is a system that feels invisibly competent: the picture pops without harshness, dialogue is clear at sane volumes, music blooms through the house without stutters, and anyone – from kids to grandparents – can use it.

That's the real flex: a setup that disappears, so the story takes centre stage. 